

C01 · KNOWING

The Stranger Across From Me

The Art of Really Knowing Someone

The Stranger Across From Me

For a few minutes you are a courteous stranger with a good ear, not a partner with a file.

1. In silence, about 5 minutes, each of you writes three questions a polite stranger could ask this person. Mix them: a memory of a year or room when they felt most like themselves; a habit a new friend would misread, and what that misreading gets wrong; a belief they rarely say in a group, asked so they can decline.
2. It qualifies only if it needs no shared history and cannot be answered in one word. Tear up anything worn out this month, and anything that is a flirt-test or a cross-examination.
3. Ask one at a time. One follow-up may ask to see the answer more clearly. It may not corner it. A declined question is a complete answer. Then swap.

Name one thing you had not known how to ask. Leave the rest on the paper.

Either of you may pass the whole card. Passing is a finished visit.



C02 · KNOWING

The Life You've Never Told Me

The Art of Really Knowing Someone

The Life You've Never Told Me

One episode the relationship has not heard, told once, without a diagnosis.

1. Alone, about 5 minutes, jot four anchors, not a script. Place: where the bodies were. The turn: the moment the day changed, in one sentence. One formative person inside this episode. What still echoes in an ordinary week now.
2. Decide who tells first. Set 8 to 10 minutes. The teller speaks or reads without interruption.
3. The listener keeps the episode in view. Do not correct a date, diagnose a family, or rush to why the teller is this way. If a matching story rises, put a hand on the table or on your own knee and leave it there until the timer is yours.
4. Swap with the same clock. A matching story after both turns is optional.

The listener says one concrete detail they are keeping, not a moral. The teller may correct that detail.

If the episode is too live tonight, say so and choose another, or pass the card.



C03 · KNOWING

The Things Nobody Thinks to Ask

The Art of Really Knowing Someone

The Things Nobody Thinks to Ask

Three questions you have never asked this person. Leave favorite colors in the other room.

1. Each of you writes three questions you have never asked. Spread them across more than one kind: belief, habit, memory, preference, private thought. You do not have to hit all five kinds tonight.
2. Examples you may discard: a money rule absorbed before you could argue with it; what your hands do in the first minute you are alone in a kitchen; a hallway that still belongs to a version of you this relationship has not met; the texture of quiet you want after a loud day.
3. Ask one. The answer can be short. One curious follow-up is allowed. Advice is not.
4. Decline any question. Then swap until each written question has been asked or retired.

Each of you names the question you are glad existed, even if you declined it.

A declined question is complete. Passing the card is complete.



C04 · KNOWING

The Museum of Me

The Art of Really Knowing Someone

The Museum of Me

You curate four pieces of a life. Your partner is a visitor, not a critic.

1. Each curator prepares four exhibits. Every label has three lines: what it is, which stretch of life it holds, and why it is in the collection. A mug, a person, a song, or a missed train can be an exhibit.
2. If all four are achievements, replace one with something ordinary, odd, or unfinished.
3. The curator speaks the labels in their own order. After each exhibit the visitor may ask one question that asks to see the piece more clearly. A question that replaces the piece with the visitor's theory does not count. Ask another, or ask none.
4. Then the visitor becomes the curator.

The visitor names the exhibit they will remember, in the curator's words, and the curator may correct the label.

Any exhibit may stay in storage. Say "not on view" and continue.



C05 · KNOWING

The Opinion I Changed

The Art of Really Knowing Someone

The Opinion I Changed

How you actually change your mind, told without a trophy.

1. Choose who goes first by appetite, not by the more impressive conversion. Set about 8 minutes.
2. The teller speaks three beats in order. The old sentence. What shifted it. How they tend to change.
3. The listener does not prosecute the current view and does not applaud a flattering conversion. They ask only: "What was the hardest part to let go?"
4. After the answer, the listener reflects the growth line in one sentence. The teller corrects it if needed. That correction is the listening. Then swap, with the same time.

If the reflection was fair, the teller says so in a few words. Stop there.

If you have no change you want to tell, pass. Passing is a complete card.



C46 · STORY

The First Chapter

The Past, the Present, and the Story of Us

The First Chapter

Write the beginning twice, apart, before either voice can steer it.

1. 10 quiet minutes. Five lines each: where it begins for you, and a different day is allowed; what you were unsure of; one detail later tellings have polished; what you guessed the other person felt; one fact you still do not know, which may stay private.
2. One person reads the five lines. The listener does not correct a name or improve a line. Private marks only: same memory, news to me, I remember it differently. Then switch.
3. Now talk. Say both beginnings and what each is counting. One curious question for the news. Set disagreements side by side, and do not average them.

Optional: one agreed fact and one uncertainty you will leave in. Or name that uncertainty and stop.

Stop if a live argument about faithfulness is waiting. Have it in plain time.

Skip any stretch you do not want replayed. No reason is required. You may stop after one scene.



C47 · STORY

The Moments You Didn’t Know Mattered

The Past, the Present, and the Story of Us

The Moments You Didn't Know Mattered

A small act you carried at a size the giver never heard. Not a performance of gratitude.

1. 8 quiet minutes. Up to five small items: a sentence, a chore, a look, a restraint, a practical save. Three should be smaller than a gift or a trip. One honest item is enough.
2. Trade one at a time: where you were, what they did, and why it stayed. The receiver lets it land and does not improve the story. One curious question. They may take a minute. A different memory does not cancel yours.
3. Switch one for one. No matching size is required. Two spoken and the rest private is complete.
4. Agreed pairs only, in two columns: what was done, and what it meant. Shrink a swollen sentence back to the gesture.

Read the columns once at their actual size. Leave the week alone.

Stop early if you want. Skip a third person's secret, and a sexual moment you have not both agreed to discuss.



C48 · STORY

Our Greatest Hits

The Past, the Present, and the Story of Us

Our Greatest Hits

Four columns. A funny story does not have to be the meaningful one.

1. Headings: funniest, most romantic, unexpected, meaningful. Quietly write a slug for each you have: place, the turn, why it plays. Empty stays empty.
2. Take one column at a time. A story may sit in two only if you both agree. Tell the place, the turn, and why it still plays.
3. The listener asks for one extra detail, names what landed, and saves their own story for their turn. If you split on whether it was funny, write both. No vote.
4. Mark keepers you both will retell, one is enough, plus one detail you will stop sanding. Read the headings, empties included.

Then stop, before the hits become a second dinner.

Humiliating a partner, or a friend who is not here, stays off. Stories about sex, bodies, or family need a yes from both.

A nomination can move to a private margin with no case to argue. You may pass a column.



C49 · STORY

The Moment I Saw You Differently

The Past, the Present, and the Story of Us

The Moment I Saw You Differently

Four beats: the smaller picture, the place, the detail that broke it, the wider one.

1. 5 quiet minutes. Sketch the smaller picture without scolding your past self, one scene, the detail that refused to fit, and the wider picture: warmer, stranger, sadder, or more accurate. Not a diagnosis. No detail means pass.
2. Speak the four beats. A minute of quiet before the listener talks.
3. They reflect the change, and may add how it felt inside the scene. They do not grind down the old picture, sweeten it, or perform the quality. A missing memory does not erase the seeing. They need not agree.
4. Switch to a different episode. Close with one line each: what you know now that you could not have known at the start.

Then stop. A tour of every misreading is a different week.

Pass an accusation or an open injury, unless you both want that scene. No third person's secret.



C50 · STORY

The Unspoken Thank-You

The Past, the Present, and the Story of Us

The Unspoken Thank-You

Finish one thanks that lost the race with the week. The cost may be wrong.

1. 8 minutes apart. Three sentences: what they did; what you think it cost them, as a guess; what changed for you. Name the act.
2. Read. The receiver takes it in, and may correct the cost with care. They do not joke it away or answer with a thanks in the same breath.
3. Switch. Size and era need not match. No unpaid thanks you believe is a finished turn: say you looked.

Ask once if a sentence may be kept. A no still leaves the spoken thanks complete. Then stop.

Do not thank a partner for harm endured, silence, or unfair work treated as a gift. A request disguised as thanks gets cut.

If resentment is still tangled in it, pick a smaller finished act or postpone. You may decline a thanks that sweetens a hard period.